



FOR REPRODUCTION

Animals may migrate to find a mate, lay eggs, give birth, and raise their young.



TO AVOID EXTREME WEATHER

In harsh wintry conditions, animals may move to areas where there is more food and warmer weather.



TO AVOID OVERCROWDING

When a population gets too big, animals may make a mass move. Locusts are one example.

BIRD MIGRATION

Bird migration takes place in spring and late autumn. The movement is triggered by changes in hours of daylight and temperature. Many migrating birds fly in V-shaped formations. The journey can last weeks or even months.

GETTING READY

Birds release a hormone to help them store fat in the weeks before they migrate.



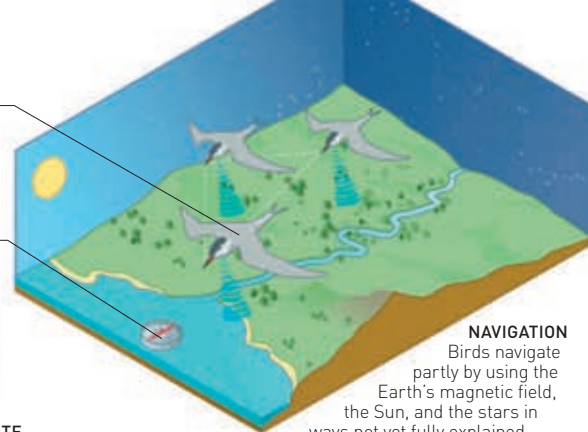
NORMAL BODY FAT



READY TO MIGRATE

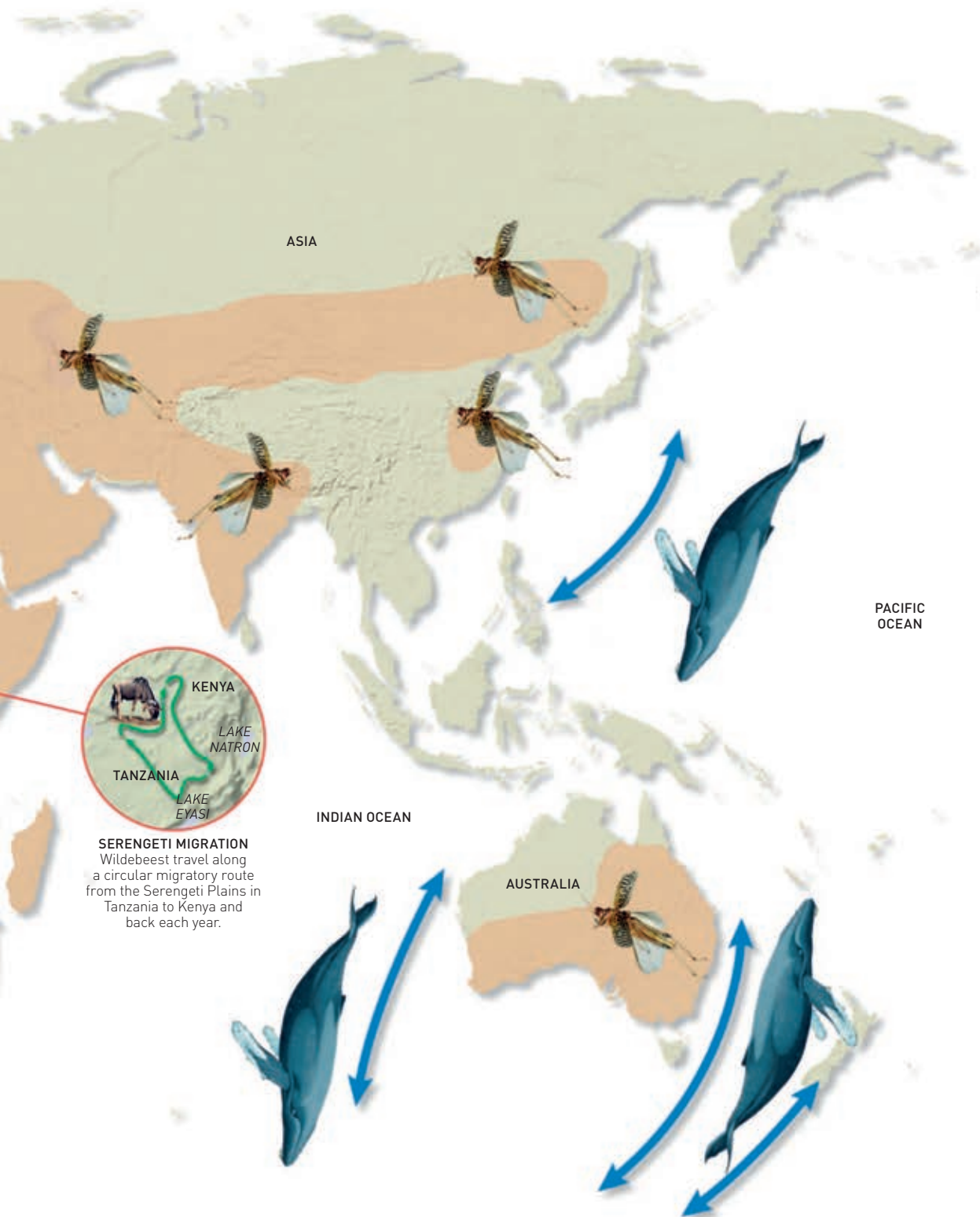
Height depends on wind patterns and landforms

The Sun and stars help to set the course



NAVIGATION

Birds navigate partly by using the Earth's magnetic field, the Sun, and the stars in ways not yet fully explained.



ASIA

PACIFIC OCEAN

INDIAN OCEAN

AUSTRALIA

KENYA

LAKE NATRON

TANZANIA

LAKE EYASI

SERENGETI MIGRATION

Wildebeest travel along a circular migratory route from the Serengeti Plains in Tanzania to Kenya and back each year.



INCA TERN

Migration ring

TRACKING MIGRATION

Scientists can track migrating animals by attaching ultra-light radio transmitters to them in various ways, such as on their legs. The little radios send signals to satellites in space, building up maps of the animals' movements. Birds are also given leg rings with unique numbers that are used to track movement.

RECORD MIGRATIONS

When animals migrate, they can travel astonishing distances, often without stopping for food or drink. Here are some world-record holders.

ARCTIC TERN

Longest round trip: 71,000 km (44,000 miles)

This tiny bird migrates further than any other animal in the world, zigzagging between Greenland and Antarctica.



BAR-TAILED GODWIT

Longest nonstop flight: 11,500 km (7,145 miles)
One of these shorebirds covered this distance in eight days without a break for food.

LEATHERBACK TURTLE

Longest recorded aquatic journey: 20,558 km (12,774 miles)

These travel across the Pacific Ocean to the beach where they were born.



WHITE-BEARED WILDEBEEST

Largest land migration: 1.3 million wildebeest
Vast herds can travel 1,610 km (1,000 miles) in a year.



BAR-HEADED GOOSE

Highest journey: 7,290 m (23,917 ft)
Flying at extreme altitude, these birds fly with only ten per cent of the oxygen found at sea level. They have been tracked flying for 17 hours without stopping.

DESERT LOCUST

Largest air migration: 69 billion locusts in one swarm
In 2004, the swarm crossed Morocco and devastated crops in parts of northwest Africa.

